THE BIG TAKEAWAYS

Given the immense potential of the sector, efficient implementation of government schemes can help it grow by leaps and bounds

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

The domestic food processing capacity has been steadily crossing 20 million tonnes in recent years. This is in a large measure due to the government's initiatives to improve the agro-industry ecosystem, creating attractive opportunities for investment, both Indian and overseas. The newly-minted minister of food processing industries Chirag Paswan has to focus on making the big-ticket programmes of the ministry work. Foremost among his tasks should be to turn around the mega food park projects. Though 41 such food parks were approved, till date, only 24 are operational while 17 are in various stages of implementation. In mid-May, the ministry came out with a consolidated list of 325 smaller food parks with funds from NABARD. Chirag must now effectively execute the projects, connect Indian producers with the domestic/ foreign market, and see the rewards flow. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

ENCOURAGE PLI SCHEMES Along with food parks, the ministry must encourage private players through production-linked incentives in ready-to-cook/ eat products, fruits/ vegetables, marine and dairy products segments

SAMPADA YOJANA In 2017, under the PM Sampada Yojana, 32 food processing projects were sanctioned in 17 states to generate employment, create processing/ preservation capacity and reduce wastage. Progress has to be speeded up

CROP VARIANTS Corporates need a better legal framework for working with farmers to grow crop variants suited for processed food. The ministry needs to work with the food & agriculture ministries and states to facilitate this



ARUN KUMAR

CHIRAG PASWAN, *41* | LJP
Minister of Food Processing Industries

Slated for big roles Born in 1982, Chirag is the son of Ram Vilas Paswan, founder of the Lok Janshakti Party, and former Union minister. After dropping out of a computer engineering course, Chirag acted in the movie *Miley Naa Miley Hum*. His leading lady? First-time MP Kangana Ranaut

Legatee of Dalit politics Paswan won from Jamui constituency in Bihar from 2014 and 2019. But in June 2021, after death of his father, a bitter struggle broke out between him and his uncle Pashupati Nath Paras over Ram Vilas's legacy. The LJP split, with Chirag leader of LJP (Ram Vilas). His star kept rising as the young Dalit leader to look out for

Redeeming the trust The NDA took note and entrusted Chirag with five LS seats. He repaid this by winning all five. Chirag is now MP from Hajipur

Minister of State

RAVNEET SINGH BITTU, *48* | BJP
Also MoS Railways